

THE COMPLETE GREEK TRAGEDIES

Edited by David Grene & Richmond Lattimore

THIRD EDITION *Edited by Mark Griffith & Glenn W. Most*

SOPHOCLES I

ANTIGONE *Translated by Elizabeth Wyckoff*

OEDIPUS THE KING *Translated by David Grene*

OEDIPUS AT COLONUS *Translated by Robert Fitzgerald*



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ANTIGONE

Translated by ELIZABETH WYCKOFF

ANTIGONE

Characters

ANTIGONE, daughter of Oedipus

ISMENE, her sister

CHORUS of Theban elders

CREON, king of Thebes

A GUARD

HAEMON, son of Creon

TEIRESIAS

A MESSENGER

EURYDICE, wife of Creon

Scene: Thebes, before the royal palace.

(Antigone and Ismene enter from the palace.)

ANTIGONE

My sister, my Ismene, do you know
of any suffering from our father sprung
that Zeus does not achieve for us survivors?
There's nothing grievous, nothing full of doom,^o

5 or shameful, or dishonored, I've not seen:
your sufferings and mine.

And now, what of this edict which they say
the commander has proclaimed to the whole people?
Have you heard anything? Or don't you know

10 that our enemies' trouble comes upon our friends?

ISMENE

I've heard no word, Antigone, of our friends,
not sweet nor bitter, since that single moment
when we two lost two brothers
who died on one day by a double blow.
15 And since the Argive army went away
this very night, I have no further news
of fortune or disaster for myself.

ANTIGONE

I knew it well, and brought you from the house
for just this reason, that you alone may hear.

ISMENE

20 What is it? Clearly some news has clouded you.

ANTIGONE

It has indeed. Creon will give the one
of our two brothers honor in the tomb;
the other none. Eteocles, with just observance treated,
25 as law provides he has hidden under earth
to have full honor with the dead below.
But Polyneices' corpse who died in pain,
they say he has proclaimed to the whole town
that none may bury him and none bewail,
but leave him, unwept, untombed, a rich sweet sight
30 for the hungry birds' beholding and devouring.

Such orders they say the worthy Creon gives
to you and me—yes, yes, I say to *me*—
and that he's coming to proclaim it clear
to those who know it not.
35 Further: he has the matter so at heart
that anyone who dares attempt the act
will die by public stoning in the town.
So there you have it and you soon will show

if you are noble, or worthless, despite your high birth.

ISMENE

If things have reached this stage, what can I do,
40 poor sister, that will help to make or mend?

ANTIGONE

Think, will you share my labor and my act?

ISMENE

What will you risk? And where is your intent?

ANTIGONE

Will you take up that corpse along with me?

ISMENE

To bury him you mean, when it's forbidden?

ANTIGONE

45 My brother, and yours, though you may wish he were not.
I never shall be found to be his traitor.

ISMENE

O reckless one, when Creon spoke against it!

ANTIGONE

It's not for him to keep me from my own.

ISMENE

Alas. Remember, sister, how our father
50 perished abhorred, ill-famed:
himself with his own hand, through his own curse
destroyed both eyes.
Remember next his mother and his wife

finishing life in the shame of the twisted noose.
55 And third, two brothers on a single day,
poor creatures, murdering, a common doom
each with his arm accomplished on the other.
And now look at the two of us alone.
We'll perish terribly if we violate law
60 and try to cross the royal vote and power.
We must remember that we two are women,
so not to fight with men;
and that since we are subject to stronger power
we must hear these orders, or any that may be worse.
65 So I shall ask of them beneath the earth
forgiveness, for in these things I am forced,
and shall obey the men in power. I know
that wild and futile action makes no sense.

ANTIGONE

I wouldn't urge it. And if now you wished
70 to act, you wouldn't please me as a partner.
Be what you want to; but that man shall I
bury. For me, the doer, death is best.
Loving, I shall lie with him, yes, with my loved one,
when I have dared the crime of piety.
Longer the time in which to please the dead
75 than the time with those up here.
There shall I lie forever. You may see fit
to keep from honor what the gods have honored.

ISMENE

I shall do no dishonor. But to act
against the citizens, that's beyond my means.

ANTIGONE

80 That's your excuse. Now I go, to heap

the burial mound for him, my dearest brother.

ISMENE

Oh my poor sister. How I fear for you!

ANTIGONE

For me, don't worry. You clear your own fate.

ISMENE

At least give no one notice of this act;
85 you keep it hidden, and I'll do the same.

ANTIGONE

Dear gods! Denounce me. I shall hate you more
if silent, not proclaiming this to all.

ISMENE

You have a hot mind over chilly things.

ANTIGONE

I know I please those whom I most should please.

ISMENE

90 If but you can. You crave what can't be done.

ANTIGONE

And so, when strength runs out, I shall give over.

ISMENE

Wrong from the start, to chase what cannot be.

ANTIGONE

If that's your saying, I shall hate you first,
and next the dead will hate you in all justice.

95 But let me and my own ill counseling
suffer this terror. I shall suffer nothing
so great as to stop me dying with honor.

ISMENE

Go, since you want to. But know this: you go
senseless indeed, but loved by those who love you.

*(Exit Ismene into the palace. Exit Antigone to one
side. Enter the Chorus from the other side.)*

CHORUS [*singing*]

STROPHE A

Sun's own radiance, fairest light ever shone on the seven gates of
100 *Thebes,*
then did you shine, O golden day's
105 *eye, coming over Dirce's stream,*
on the man who had come from Argos with all his armor
running now in headlong fear as you shook his bridle free.

[*chanting*]

110 *He was stirred by the dubious quarrel of Polyneices.*
So, screaming shrill,
like an eagle over the land he flew,
covered with white-snow wing,
115 *with many weapons,*
with horse-hair crested helms.

ANTISTROPHE A [*singing*]

He who had stood above our halls, gaping about our seven gates,
with that circle of blood-thirsting spears:
120 *gone, without our blood in his jaws,*
before the torch took hold on our tower crown.
125 *Rattle of war at his back; hard the fight for the dragon's foe.*

[chanting]

The boasts of a proud tongue are for Zeus to hate.

So seeing them streaming on

130 *in insolent clangor of gold,*

he struck with hurling fire him who rushed

for the high wall's top,

hoping to yell out "victory."

STROPHE B [singing]

Swinging, striking the earth he fell

135 *fire in hand, who in mad attack,*

had raged against us with blasts of hate.

He failed. And differently from one to another

on both sides great Ares dealt his blows about,

140 *first in our war team.*

[chanting]

The captains assigned for seven gates

fought with our seven and left behind

their brazen arms as an offering

to Zeus who is turner of battle.

All but those two wretches, sons of one man,

145 *one mother's sons, who planted their spears*

each against each and found the share

of a common death together.

ANTISTROPHE B [singing]

Great-named Victory comes to us

answering Thebe's warrior joy.

150 *Let us forget the wars just done*

and visit the shrines of the gods,

all, with night-long dance which Bacchus will lead,

he who shakes Thebe's acres.

(Creon enters from the side.)

[chanting]

155 *Now here he comes, the king of the land,
Creon, Menoeceus' son,
newly appointed by the gods' new fate.
What plan that beats about his mind*
160 *has made him call this council session,
sending his summons to all?*

CREON

My friends, the very gods who shook the state
with mighty surge have set it straight again.
So now I sent for you, chosen from all,
165 first, because I knew you constant in respect
to Laius' royal power; and again
when Oedipus had set the state to rights,
and when he perished, you were faithful still
in mind to the descendants of the dead.
170 When they two perished by a double fate,
on one day struck and striking and defiled
each by each other's hand, now it comes that I
hold all the power and the royal throne
through close connection with the perished men.
175 You cannot learn of any man the soul,
the mind, and the intent until he shows
his practice of the government and law.
For I believe that he who controls the state
if he holds not to the best plans of all,
180 but locks his tongue up through some kind of fear,
he is worst of all who are or were.
And he who counts another greater friend
than his own fatherland, I put him nowhere.
So I—may Zeus all-seeing always know it—

185 could not keep silent as disaster crept
upon the town, destroying hope of safety.
Nor could I count the enemy of the land
friend to myself, not I who know so well
that it's she, the land, who saves us, sailing straight,
190 and only so can we have friends at all.

With such good rules shall I enlarge our state.
And now I have proclaimed their brother-edict.
In the matter of the sons of Oedipus,
citizens, know: Eteocles who died,
195 defending this our town with champion spear,
is to be covered in the grave and granted
all holy rites we give the noble dead.
But his brother Polyneices, whom I name
the exile who came back and sought to burn
200 his fatherland, the gods of his own kin,
who tried to gorge on blood he shared, and lead
the rest of us as slaves—
it is announced that no one in this town
may give him burial or mourn for him.
205 Leave him unburied, leave his corpse disgraced,
a dinner for the birds and for the dogs.
Such is my mind. Never shall I, myself,
honor the wicked and reject the just.
The man who is well-minded to the state
210 from me in death and life shall have his honor.

CHORUS LEADER

This resolution, Creon, is your own,
in the matter of the traitor and the true.
For you can make such rulings as you will
about the living and about the dead.

CREON

215 Now you be sentinels of the decree.

CHORUS LEADER

Order some younger man to take this on.

CREON

Already there are watchers of the corpse.

CHORUS LEADER

What other order would you give us, then?

CREON

Not to take sides with any who disobey.

CHORUS LEADER

220 No fool is fool to the point of loving death.

CREON

Death is the price. But often we have known
men to be ruined by the hope of profit.

(Enter, from the side, a Guard.)

GUARD

My lord, I cannot claim I'm out of breath
from rushing here with light and hasty step,
225 for I had many haltings in my thought
making me double back upon my road.
My mind kept saying many things to me:
"Why go where you will surely pay the price?"
"Fool, are you halting? And if Creon learns
230 from someone else, how shall you not be hurt?"
Turning this over, on I dillydallied.
And so a short trip turned itself to long.

Finally, though, my coming here won out.
If what I say is nothing, still I'll say it.
235 For I come clutching to one single hope
that I can't suffer what is not my fate.

CREON

What is it that brings on this gloom of yours?

GUARD

I want to tell you first about myself.
I didn't do it, didn't see who did it.
240 It isn't right for me to get in trouble.

CREON

Your aim is good. You fence the facts around.
It's clear you have some shocking news to tell.

GUARD

Terrible tidings make for long delays.

CREON

Speak out the story, and then get away.

GUARD

245 I'll tell you. Someone left the corpse just now,
burial all accomplished, thirsty dust
strewn on the flesh, the ritual complete.

CREON

What are you saying? What man has dared to do it?

GUARD

I wouldn't know. There were no marks of picks,
250 no grubbed-out earth. The ground was dry and hard,

no trace of wheels. The doer left no sign.
When the first fellow on the day-shift showed us,
we all were sick with wonder.
255 For he was hidden, not inside a tomb,
but light dust upon him, enough to avert pollution;
no wild beast's track, nor track of any hound
having been near, nor was the body torn.
260 We roared bad words about, guard against guard,
almost came to blows. No one was there to stop us.
Each man had done it, nobody had done it
so as to prove it on him—we couldn't tell.
We were prepared to hold to red-hot iron,
265 to walk through fire, to swear before the gods
we hadn't done it, hadn't shared the plan,
when it was plotted or when it was done.
And last, when all our sleuthing came out nowhere,
one fellow spoke, who made our heads to droop
270 low toward the ground. We couldn't disagree.
We couldn't see a chance of getting off.
He said we had to tell you all about it.
We couldn't hide the fact.
So he won out. The lot chose poor old me
275 to win the prize. So here I am unwilling,
quite sure you people hardly want to see me.
Nobody likes the bringer of bad news.

CHORUS LEADER

Lord, while he spoke, my mind kept on debating.
Isn't this action possibly a god's?

CREON

280 Stop now, before you fill me up with rage,
or you'll prove yourself insane as well as old.
Unbearable, your saying that the gods

take any kindly forethought for this corpse.
Would it be they had hidden him away,
285 honoring his good service, he who came
to burn their pillared temples and their wealth,
raze their land, and break apart their laws?
Or have you seen them honor wicked men?
It isn't so.
290 No, from the first there were some men in town
who took the edict hard, and growled against me,
who secretly were shaking their heads, not pulling
honestly in the yoke, no way my friends.
These are the people—oh it's clear to me—
295 who have bribed these men and brought about the deed.
No current standard among men's as bad
as silver currency. This destroys the state;
this drives men from their homes; this wicked teacher
drives solid citizens to acts of shame.
300 It shows men how to act as criminals
and know the deeds of utter unholiness.
But every hired hand who helped in this
has brought on himself the sentence he shall have.
And further, as I still revere great Zeus,
305 understand this, I tell you under oath:
if you don't find the very man whose hands
buried the corpse and bring him for me to see,
not death alone shall be enough for you
till living, strung up, you make clear the crime.
310 For the future you'll have learned that profiteering
has its rules, and that it doesn't pay
to squeeze a profit out of every source.
For you'll have seen that more men come to doom
through dirty profits than are sustained by them.

GUARD

315 May I say something? Or just turn and go?

CREON

Aren't you aware your speech is most unwelcome?

GUARD

Does it annoy your ears, or your mind?

CREON

Why are you out to allocate my pain?

GUARD

The doer hurts your mind. I hurt your ears.

CREON

320 You are a quibbling rascal through and through.

GUARD

But anyhow I never did the deed.

CREON

And you the man who sold your life for money!

GUARD

Oh!

How terrible to guess, and guess at lies!

CREON

Go polish up your guesswork. If you don't
325 show me the doers you will have to say
that wicked payments work their own revenge.

GUARD

Indeed, I pray he's found, but yes or no,

taken or not as luck may settle it,
you won't see me returning to this place.
330 Saved when I neither hoped nor thought to be,
I owe the gods a mighty debt of thanks.

(Exit Creon into the palace. Exit the Guard by the way he came.)

CHORUS [*singing*]

STROPHE A

Many the wonders but nothing is stranger than man.
335 *This thing crosses the sea in the winter's storm,*
making his path through the roaring waves.
And she, the greatest of gods, the Earth—
ageless she is, and unwearied—he wears her away
340 *as the ploughs go up and down from year to year*
and his mules turn up the soil.

ANTISTROPHE A

Lighthearted nations of birds he snares and leads,
345 *wild beast tribes and the salty brood of the sea,*
with the twisted mesh of his nets, this clever man.
He controls with craft the beasts of the open air,
350 *walkers on hills. The horse with his shaggy mane*
he holds and harnesses, yoked about the neck,
and the strong bull of the mountain.

STROPHE B

Language, and thought like the wind
355 *and the feelings that govern a city,*
he has taught himself, and shelter against the cold,
refuge from rain. He can always help himself.
He faces no future helpless. There's only death
360 *that he cannot find an escape from. He has contrived*

refuge from illnesses once beyond all cure.

ANTISTROPHE B

Clever beyond all dreams
365 *the inventive craft that he has*
which may drive him one time to good or another to evil.
When he honors the laws of the land and the gods' sworn right
370 *high indeed is his city; but cityless the man*
who dares to dwell with dishonor. Not by my fireside,
375 *never to share my thoughts, who does these things.*

(Enter the Guard with Antigone, from the side.)

[Chorus now chanting]
My mind is split at this awful sight.
I know her. I cannot deny
Antigone is here.
Alas, the unhappy girl,
380 *unhappy Oedipus' child.*
Oh what is the meaning of this?
It cannot be you that they bring
for breaking the royal law,
caught in sheer madness.

GUARD

This is the woman who has done the deed.
385 *We caught her at the burying. Where's the king?*

(Enter Creon from the palace.)

CHORUS LEADER

Back from the house again just when he's needed.

CREON

What must I measure up to? What has happened?

GUARD

Lord, one should never swear off anything.

Afterthought makes the first resolve a liar.

390 I could have vowed I wouldn't come back here
after your threats, after the storm I faced.

But joy that comes beyond the wildest hope
is bigger than all other pleasure known.

395 I'm here, though I swore not to be, and bring
this girl. We caught her burying the dead.

This time we didn't need to shake the lots;
mine was the luck, all mine.

So now, lord, take her, you, and question her
and prove her as you will. But I am free.

400 And I deserve full clearance on this charge.

CREON

Explain the circumstance of the arrest.

GUARD

She was burying the man. You have it all.

CREON

Is this the truth? And do you grasp its meaning?

GUARD

I saw her burying the very corpse

405 you had forbidden. Is this adequate?

CREON

How was she caught and taken in the act?

GUARD

It was like this: when we got back again

struck with those dreadful threatenings of yours,
410 we swept away the dust that hid the corpse.
We stripped it back to slimy nakedness.
And then we sat to windward on the hill
so as to dodge the smell.
We poked each other up with growling threats
if anyone was careless of his work.
415 For some time this went on, till it was noon.
The sun was high and hot. Then from the earth
up rose a dusty whirlwind to the sky,
filling the plain, smearing the forest leaves,
420 clogging the upper air. We shut our eyes,
sat and endured the plague the gods had sent.
Then the storm left us after a long time.
We saw the girl. She cried the sharp and shrill
cry of a bitter bird which sees the nest
425 bare where the young birds lay.
So this same girl, seeing the body stripped,
cried with great groanings, called out dreadful curses
upon the people who had done the deed.
Soon in her hands she brought the thirsty dust,
430 and holding high a pitcher of wrought bronze
she poured the three libations for the dead.
We saw this and rushed down. We trapped her fast;
and she was calm. We taxed her with the deeds
435 both past and present. Nothing was denied.
And I was glad, and yet I took it hard.
One's own escape from trouble makes one glad;
but bringing friends to trouble is hard grief.
Still, I care less for all these second thoughts
440 than for the fact that I myself am safe.

CREON

You there, whose head is drooping to the ground,

do you admit this, or deny you did it?

ANTIGONE

I say I did it and I don't deny it.

(To the Guard.)

CREON

Take yourself off wherever you wish to go
445 free of a heavy charge.

(To Antigone.)

You—tell me not at length but in a word.

You knew the order not to do this thing?

ANTIGONE

I knew—of course I knew. The word was plain.

CREON

And still you dared to overstep these laws?

ANTIGONE

450 For me it was not Zeus who made that order.
Nor did that Justice who lives with the gods below
mark out such laws to hold among mankind.
Nor did I think your orders were so strong
that you, a mortal man, could overrun
455 the gods' unwritten and unfailing laws.
Not now, nor yesterday's, they always live,
and no one knows their origin in time.
So not through fear of any man's proud spirit
would I be likely to neglect these laws,
and draw on myself the gods' sure punishment.
460 I knew that I must die—how could I not?—

even without your edict. If I die
before my time, I say it is a gain.
Who lives in sorrows many as are mine
how shall he not be glad to gain his death?
465 And so, for me to meet this fate's no grief.
But if I left that corpse, my mother's son,
dead and unburied I'd have cause to grieve
as now I grieve not.
And if you think my acts are foolishness
470 the foolishness may be in a fool's eye.

CHORUS LEADER

The girl is fierce. She's her father's child.
She cannot yield to trouble; nor could he.

CREON

These rigid spirits are the first to fall.
475 The strongest iron, hardened in the fire,
most often ends in scraps and shatterings.
Small curbs bring raging horses back to terms:
enslaved to his neighbor, who can think of pride?
480 This girl was expert in her insolence
when she broke bounds beyond established law.
Once she had done it, insolence the second,
to boast her doing, and to laugh in it.
I am no man and she the man instead
485 if she can have this conquest without pain.
She is my sister's child, but were she child
of closer kin than any at my hearth,
she and her sister should not so escape
a dreadful death. I charge Ismene too.
490 She shared the planning of this burial.
Call her outside. I saw her in the house,
maddened, no longer mistress of herself.

The sly intent betrays itself sometimes
before the secret plotters work their wrong.
495 I hate it too when someone caught in crime
then wants to make it seem a lovely thing.

ANTIGONE

Do you want more than my arrest and death?

CREON

No more than that. For that is all I need.

ANTIGONE

Why are you waiting? Nothing that you say
500 fits with my thought. I pray it never will.
Nor will you ever like to hear my words.
And yet what greater glory could I find
than giving my own brother funeral?
All these would say that they approved my act
505 did fear not mute them.
A king is fortunate in many ways,
and most, that he can act and speak at will.

CREON

None of these others see the case this way.

ANTIGONE

They see, and do not say. You have them cowed.

CREON

510 And you are not ashamed to think alone?

ANTIGONE

It is no shame to serve blood relatives.

CREON

Was not he who died on the other side your brother?

ANTIGONE

Full brother, on both sides, my parents' child.

CREON

Your act of grace, in his regard, is crime.

ANTIGONE

⁵¹⁵ The corpse below would never say it was.

CREON

When you honor him and the criminal just alike?

ANTIGONE

It was a brother, not a slave, who died.

CREON

Died to destroy this land the other guarded.

ANTIGONE

Death yearns for equal law for all the dead.

CREON

⁵²⁰ Not that the good and bad draw equal shares.

ANTIGONE

Who knows but this is holiness below?

CREON

Never is the enemy, even in death, a friend.

ANTIGONE

I cannot share in hatred, but in love.

CREON

Then go down there, if you must love, and love
525 the dead. No woman rules me while I live.

(Ismene is brought from the palace under guard.)

CHORUS [*chanting*]

*Look there! Ismene is coming out.
She loves her sister and mourns,
with clouded brow and bloodied cheeks,
530 tears on her lovely face.*

CREON

You, lurking like a viper in the house,
who sucked me dry, while I raised unawares
a twin destruction planned against the throne.
Now tell me, do you say you shared this deed?
535 Or will you swear you didn't even know?

ISMENE

I did the deed if she agrees I did.
I am accessory and share the blame.

ANTIGONE

Justice will not allow this. You did not
wish for a part, nor did I give you one.

ISMENE

540 You are in trouble, and I'm not ashamed
to sail beside you into suffering.

ANTIGONE

Death and the dead, they know whose act it was.
I cannot love a friend whose love's mere words.

ISMENE

Sister, I pray, don't fence me out from honor,
545 from death with you, and honor done the dead.

ANTIGONE

Don't die along with me, nor make your own
that which you did not do. My death's enough.

ISMENE

When you are gone what life can I desire?

ANTIGONE

Love Creon. He's your kinsman and your care.

ISMENE

550 Why hurt me, when it does yourself no good?

ANTIGONE

I also suffer, when I laugh at you.

ISMENE

What further service can I do you now?

ANTIGONE

To save yourself. I shall not envy you.

ISMENE

Alas for me. Am I outside your fate?

ANTIGONE

555 Yes. For you chose to live when I chose death.

ISMENE

At least I was not silent. You were warned.

ANTIGONE

Some will have thought you wiser. Some will not.

ISMENE

And yet the blame is equal for us both.

ANTIGONE

Take heart. You live. My life died long ago.

560 And that has made me fit to help the dead.

CREON

One of these girls has shown her lack of sense
just now. The other had it from her birth.

ISMENE

Yes, king. When people fall in deep distress
their native sense departs, and will not stay.

CREON

565 You chose your mind's distraction when you chose
to work out wickedness with this wicked girl.

ISMENE

What life is there for me to live without her?

CREON

Don't speak of her. For she is here no more.

ISMENE

But will you kill your own son's promised bride?

CREON

Oh, there are other furrows for his plough.

ISMENE

570 But where the closeness that has bound these two?

CREON

Not for my sons will I choose wicked wives.

ISMENE^o

Dear Haemon, your father robs you of your rights.

CREON

You and your marriage trouble me too much.

ISMENE

You will take away his bride from your own son?

CREON

575 Yes. Death will help me break this marriage off.

CHORUS LEADER

It seems determined that the girl must die.

CREON

You helped determine it. Now, no delay!

Slaves, take them in. They must be women now.

No more free running.

580 Even the bold will flee when they see Death
drawing in close enough to end their life.

(Antigone and Ismene are taken inside.)

CHORUS [*singing*]

STROPHE A

Fortunate they whose lives have no taste of pain.
585 *For those whose house is shaken by the gods*
escape no kind of doom. It extends to all the kin
like the wave that comes when the winds of Thrace
run over the dark of the sea.
590 *The black sand of the bottom is brought from the depth;*
the beaten cliffs sound back with a hollow cry.

ANTISTROPHE A

Ancient the sorrow of Labdacus' house, I know.
595 *Dead men's grief comes back, and falls on grief.*
No generation can free the next.
One of the gods will strike. There is no escape.
So now the light goes out
600 *for the house of Oedipus, while the bloody knife*
cuts the remaining root, in folly and the mind's fury.

STROPHE B

What transgression of man, O Zeus, can bind your power?
606 *Not sleep can destroy it who governs all,*
nor the weariless months the gods have set. Unaged in time
610 *monarch you rule in Olympus' gleaming light.*
Near time, far future, and the past,
one law controls them all:
any greatness in human life brings doom.

ANTISTROPHE B

Wandering hope brings help to many men.
616 *But others she tricks with giddy loves,*
and her quarry knows nothing until he has walked into flame.
620 *Word of wisdom it was when someone said,*
"The bad looks like the good"

to him a god would doom.”
625 *Only briefly is that one free from doom.*

(Haemon enters from the side.)

[*chanting*]
Here is Haemon, your one surviving son.
Does he come in grief at the fate of his bride,
630 *in pain that he's tricked of his wedding?*

CREON

Soon we shall know more than a seer could tell us.
Son, have you heard the vote condemned your bride?
And are you here, maddened against your father,
or are we friends, whatever I may do?

HAEMON

635 My father, I am yours. You keep me straight
with your good judgment, which I shall ever follow.
Nor shall a marriage count for more with me
than your kind leading.

CREON

There's my good boy. So should you hold at heart
640 and stand behind your father all the way.
It is for this men pray they may beget
households of dutiful obedient sons,
who share alike in punishing enemies,
and give due honor to their father's friends.
645 Whoever breeds a child that will not help,
what has he sown but trouble for himself,
and for his enemies laughter full and free?
Son, do not let your lust mislead your mind,
all for a woman's sake, for well you know
650 how cold the thing he takes into his arms

who has a wicked woman for his wife.
What deeper wound than a loved one who is evil?
Oh spit her forth forever, as your foe.
Let the girl marry somebody in Hades.
655 Since I have caught her in the open act,
the only one in town who disobeyed,
I shall not now proclaim myself a liar,
but kill her. Let her sing her song of Zeus
the guardian of blood kin.
If I allow disorder in my house
660 I'd surely have to license it abroad.
A man who deals in fairness with his own,
he can make manifest justice in the state.
But he who crosses law, or forces it,
or hopes to dictate orders to the rulers,
665 shall never have a word of praise from me.
The man the state has put in place must have
obedient hearing to his least command
when it is right, and even when it's not.
He who accepts this teaching I can trust,
ruler, or ruled, to function in his place,
670 to stand his ground even in the storm of spears,
a comrade to trust in battle at one's side.
There is no greater wrong than disobedience.
This ruins cities, this tears down our homes,
this breaks the battlefront in panic-rout.
If men live decently it is because
675 obedience saves their very lives for them.
So I must guard the men who yield to order,
not let myself be beaten by a woman.
Better, if it must happen, that a man
should overset me.
680 I won't be called weaker than womankind.

CHORUS LEADER

We think—unless our age is cheating us—
that what you say is sensible and right.

HAEMON

Father, the gods have given men good sense,
the highest and best possession that we have.
685 I couldn't find the words in which to claim
that there was error in your late remarks.
Yet someone else might bring some further light.
Because I am your son I must keep watch
on all men's doing where it touches you,
their speech, and most of all, their discontents.
690 Your presence frightens any common man
from saying things you would not care to hear.
But in dark corners I have heard them say
how the whole town is grieving for this girl,
unjustly doomed, if ever woman was,
695 to die in shame for glorious action done.
She would not leave her fallen, slaughtered brother
there, as he lay, unburied, for the birds
and hungry dogs to make an end of him.
Does she not truly deserve a golden prize?
700 This is the undercover speech in town.
 Father, your welfare is my greatest good.
What precious gift in life for any child
outweighs a father's fortune and good fame?
And so a father feels his children's faring.
705 So, do not have one mind, and one alone
that only your opinion can be right.
Whoever thinks that he alone is wise,
his eloquence, his mind, above the rest,
come the unfolding, it shows his emptiness.
710 A man, though wise, should never be ashamed

of learning more, and must not be too rigid.
Have you not seen the trees beside storm torrents—
the ones that bend preserve their limbs and leaves,
while the resistant perish root and branch?

715 And so the ship that will not slacken sail,
the ropes drawn tight, unyielding, overturns.
She ends the voyage with her keel on top.
No, yield your wrath, allow a change of stand.
Young as I am, if I may give advice,
720 I'd say it would be best if men were born
perfect in wisdom, but that failing this
(which often fails) it can be no dishonor
to learn from others when they speak good sense.

CHORUS LEADER

Lord, if your son has spoken to the point
725 you should take his lesson. He should do the same.
Both sides have spoken well.

CREON

At my age I'm to school my mind by his?
This boy instructor is my master, then?

HAEMON

I urge no wrong. I'm young, but you should watch
my actions, not my years, to judge of me.

CREON

730 A loyal action, to respect disorder?

HAEMON

I wouldn't urge respect for wickedness.

CREON

You don't think she is sick with that disease?

HAEMON

Your fellow citizens maintain she's not.

CREON

Is the town to tell me how I ought to rule?

HAEMON

735 Now there you speak just like a boy yourself.

CREON

Am I to rule by other mind than mine?

HAEMON

No city is property of a single man.

CREON

But custom gives possession to the ruler.

HAEMON

You'd rule a desert beautifully alone.

(To the Chorus.)

CREON

740 It seems he's firmly on the woman's side.

HAEMON

If you're a woman. It is you I care for.

CREON

Wicked, to try conclusions with your father.

HAEMON

When you conclude unjustly, so I must.

CREON

Am I unjust, when I respect my office?

HAEMON

745 You don't respect it, trampling down the gods' due.

CREON

Your mind is poisoned. Weaker than a woman!

HAEMON

At least you'll never see me yield to shame.

CREON

Your whole long argument is but for her.

HAEMON

And you, and me, and for the gods below.

CREON

750 As long as she lives, you shall not marry her.

HAEMON

Then she shall die—and her death will bring another.

CREON

Your boldness makes more progress. Threats, indeed!

HAEMON

No threat, to speak against your empty plan.

CREON

Past due, sharp lessons for your empty brain.

HAEMON

⁷⁵⁵ If you weren't father, I should call you mad.

CREON

Don't flatter me with "father," you woman's slave.

HAEMON

You wish to speak but never wish to hear.

CREON

You think so? By Olympus, you shall not
revile me with these tauntings and go free.

⁷⁶⁰ Bring out the hateful creature; she shall die
full in his sight, close at her bridegroom's side.

HAEMON

Not at my side! Don't think that! She will not
die next to me. And you yourself will not
ever lay eyes upon my face again.

⁷⁶⁵ Find other friends to rave with after this.

(Exit Haemon, to the side.)

CHORUS LEADER

Lord, he has gone with all the speed of rage.
When such a young man is grieved his mind is hard.

CREON

Oh, let him go, and plan superhuman action.
In any case the girls shall not escape.

CHORUS LEADER

770 You plan the punishment of death for both?

CREON

Not her who did not do it. You are right.

CHORUS LEADER

And what death have you chosen for the other?

CREON

To take her where the foot of man comes not.
There shall I hide her in a hollowed cave
775 living, and leave her just so much to eat
as clears the city from the guilt of death.
There, if she prays to Death, the only god
of her respect, she may manage not to die.
Or she may learn at last, though much too late,
780 how honoring the dead is wasted labor.

(Exit Creon into the palace.)°

CHORUS [*singing*]

STROPHE

Love unconquered in fight, love who falls on our possessions:°
You rest at night in the soft bloom of a girl's face.

785 *You cross the sea, you are known in the wildest lairs.*
Not the immortal gods can escape you,
790 *nor men of a day. Who has you within him is mad.*

ANTISTROPHE

You twist the minds of the just. Wrong they pursue and are ruined.
You made this quarrel of kindred men before us now.
795 *Desire looks clear from the eyes of a lovely bride:*
power as strong as the founded world.
800 *Aphrodite, goddess, is playing, with whom no man can fight.*

(Antigone is brought from the palace under guard.)

[chanting]

Now I am carried beyond all bounds.
My tears will not be checked.
I see Antigone depart
805 *to the chamber where all must sleep.*

ANTIGONE [singing]

STROPHE A

Men of my fathers' land, you see me go
my last journey. My last sight of the sun,
810 *then never again. Death who brings all to sleep*
takes me alive to the shore
of the river underground.
815 *Not for me was the marriage hymn, nor will anyone start the song*
at a wedding of mine. Acheron is my bridegroom.

CHORUS [chanting]

With praise as your portion you go
in fame to the vault of the dead.
Untouched by wasting disease,
820 *not paying the price of the sword,*

*of your own free will you go.
Alone among mortals will you descend
in life to the house of Death.*

ANTIGONE [*singing*]

ANTISTROPHE A

*Pitiful was the death that Phrygian stranger died,
825 our queen once, Tantalus' daughter. The rock by Sipylus
covered her over, like stubborn ivy it grew.
Still, as she wastes, the rain
and snow companion her, so men say.
Pouring down from her mourning eyes comes the water that
830 soaks the stone.
My own putting to sleep a god has arranged like hers.*

CHORUS [*chanting*]

*God's child and god she was:
835 but we are born to death.
Yet even in death you will have your fame,
to have gone like a god to your fate,
in living and dying alike.*

ANTIGONE [*singing*]

STROPHE B

*Laughter against me now. In the name of our fathers' gods,
840 could you not wait till I went? Must affront be thrown in my face?
O city of wealthy men.
I call upon Dirce's spring,
845 I call upon Thebe's grove in the armored plain,
to be my witnesses, how with no friend's mourning,
by what decree I go to the fresh-made prison tomb.
850 Alive to the place of corpses, an alien still,*

never at home with the living nor with the dead.

CHORUS

*You went to the furthest verge
of daring, but there you tripped
855 on the high pedestal of justice, and fell.
Perhaps you are paying your father's pain.*

ANTIGONE

ANTISTROPHE B

*You speak of my darkest thought, my pitiful father's fame,
860 spread through all the world, and the doom that haunts our house,
the glorious house of Labdacus.
My mother's marriage bed.
865 Destruction where she lay with her husband-son,
my father. These are my parents and I their child.
I go to stay with them. My curse is to die unwed.
870 My brother, you found your fate when you found your bride,
you found it for me as well. Dead, you destroy my life.*

CHORUS

*You showed respect for the dead.
So we for you: but power
is not to be thwarted so.
875 Your self-willed temper has brought you down.*

ANTIGONE

EPODE

*Unwept, no wedding-song, unfriended, now I go
down the road made ready for me.
880 No longer am I allowed to see this holy light of the sun.
No friend bewails my fate.*

(Creon enters from the palace.)°

CREON

When people sing the dirge for their own deaths
ahead of time, no one would ever stop
if they might hope that this would be of use.°
885 Take her away at once, and open up
the tomb I spoke of. Leave her there alone.
There let her choose: death, or a buried life.
No stain of guilt upon us in this case,
890 but she is exiled from our life on earth.

ANTIGONE

O tomb, O marriage chamber, hollowed-out
house that will watch forever, where I go—
to my own people, most of whom are there;
Persephone has taken them to her.
895 Last of them all, beyond the rest ill-fated,
I shall descend, before my course is run.
Still when I get there I may hope to find
I've come as a dear friend to my dear father,
to you, my mother, and my brother too.
900 All three of you have known my hand in death.
I washed your bodies, dressed them for the grave,
poured out the last libation at the tomb.
And now, Polyneices, you know the price I pay
for doing final service to your corpse.
And yet the wise will know my choice was right.
905 Were I a mother, with children or husband dead,
I'd let them molder. I should not have chosen
in such a case to cross the state's decree.
What is the law that lies behind these words?
One husband gone, I might have found another,
910 or a child from a new man in the first child's place;

but with my parents covered up in death,
no brother for me, ever, could be born.
Such was the law by which I honored you.
915 But Creon thought the doing was a crime,
a dreadful daring, brother of my heart.
So now he takes and leads me out by force.
No marriage bed, no marriage song for me,
and since no wedding, so no child to rear.
I go, without a friend, struck down by fate,
920 living, to the hollow chambers of the dead.
What divine justice have I disobeyed?
Why, in my misery, look to the gods for help?
Can I call any of them my ally?
I stand convicted of impiety,
the evidence my pious duty done.
925 If the gods think that this is righteousness,
in suffering I'll see my error clear.
But if it is the others who are wrong
I wish them no greater punishment than mine.

CHORUS [*Chorus, Creon, and Antigone chanting in turn*]

The same tempest of mind
930 *as ever, controls the girl.*

CREON

Therefore her guards shall regret
the slowness with which they move.

ANTIGONE

That word comes close to death.

CREON

You are perfectly right in that;
935 *I offer no grounds for hope.*

ANTIGONE

O town of my fathers in Thebe's land,

O gods of our house!

I am led away and must not wait.

940 *Look, leaders of Thebes,*

I am last of your royal line.

Look what I suffer, at whose command,

because I respected the right.

(Antigone is led away, to the side.)

CHORUS [*singing*]

STROPHE A

Danaë suffered too.

945 *She went from the light to the brass-built room,
bedchamber and tomb together. Like you, poor child,
she was of great descent, and more, she held and kept*

950 *the seed of the golden rain which was Zeus.*

Fate has terrible power.

You cannot escape it by wealth or war.

No fort will keep it out, no ships outrun it.

ANTISTROPHE A

955 *Remember the angry king,
son of Dryas, who raged against Dionysus and paid,
pent in a rock-walled prison. His bursting wrath
slowly went down. As the terror of madness went,*

960 *he learned of his frenzied attack on the god.*

*Fool, he had tried to stop
the dancing women possessed of god,*

965 *the fire of Bacchic rites, the songs and pipes.*

STROPHE B

*Where the dark rocks divide
sea from sea at the Bosphorus,
970 is Thracian Salmydessus, where savage Ares
beheld the terrible blinding wounds
975 dealt to Phineus' sons by their father's wife.
Dark the eyes that looked to avenge their mother.
Sharp with her shuttle she struck, and blooded her hands.* °

ANTISTROPHE B

*Wasting they wept their fate,
980 settled when they were born
to Cleopatra, unhappy queen.
She was a princess too, of the ancient Erechthids,
985 but was reared in the cave of the wild North Wind, her father,
swift as a horse over the hills.
Half a goddess, still, child, she suffered like you.*

(Enter, from the side, Teiresias, led by a boy attendant.)

TEIRESIAS

Elders of Thebes, we two have come one road,
two of us looking through one pair of eyes.
990 This is the way of walking for the blind.

CREON

Old Teiresias, what news has brought you here?

TEIRESIAS

I'll tell you. You in turn must trust the prophet.

CREON

I've always been attentive to your counsel.

TEIRESIAS

And therefore you have steered this city straight.

CREON

995 So I can say how helpful you have been.

TEIRESIAS

Again you are balanced on a razor's edge.

CREON

What is it? How I shudder at your words!

TEIRESIAS

You'll know, when you hear the signs that I have marked.

1000 I sat where every bird of heaven comes
in my old place of augury, and heard
bird cries I'd never known. They screeched about
goaded by madness, inarticulate.

I marked that they were tearing one another
with claws of murder. I could hear the wing-beats.

1005 I was afraid, so straightaway I tried
burnt sacrifice upon the flaming altar.
No fire caught my offerings. Slimy ooze
dripped on the ashes, smoked and sputtered there.

1010 Gall burst its bladder, vanished into vapor;
the fat dripped from the bones and would not burn.
These are the omens of the rites that failed,
as this boy here has told me. He's my guide
as I am guide to others.

1015 Why has this sickness struck against the state?
Through your decision.
All of the altars of the town are choked
with leavings of the dogs and birds; their feast
was on that fated, fallen son of Oedipus.
So the gods accept no offering from us,

1020 not prayer, nor flame of sacrifice. The birds
cry out a sound that I cannot distinguish,
gorged with the greasy blood of that dead man.
Think of these things, my son. All men may err,
but error once committed, he's no fool
1025 nor unsuccessful, who can change his mind
and cure the trouble he has fallen in.
Stubbornness and stupidity are twins.
Yield to the dead. Why goad him where he lies?
1030 What use to kill the dead a second time?
I speak for your own good. And I am right.
Learning from a wise counselor is not pain
if what he speaks are profitable words.

CREON

Old man, you all, like bowmen at a mark,
have bent your bows at me. I've had my share
1035 of seers: I've been an item in your accounts.
Make profit, trade in Lydian electrum,
pure gold of India; that's your chief desire.
But you will never cover up that corpse,
1040 not if the very eagles tear their food
from him, and leave it at the throne of Zeus.
I wouldn't give him up for burial
in fear of that pollution. For I know
no mortal being can pollute the gods.
1045 Yes, old Teiresias, human beings fall;
the clever ones the furthest, when they plead
a shameful case so well in hope of profit.

TEIRESIAS

Alas!
What man can tell me, has he thought at all ...

CREON

What tired cliché's coming from your lips?

TEIRESIAS

¹⁰⁵⁰ How the best of all possessions is good counsel.

CREON

And so is foolishness the worst of all.

TEIRESIAS

But you're infected with that same disease.

CREON

I'm reluctant to be uncivil to a seer ...

TEIRESIAS

You're that already. You have said I lie.

CREON

¹⁰⁵⁵ Well, the whole crew of seers are money-mad.

TEIRESIAS

And the whole tribe of tyrants grab at gain.

CREON

Do you realize you are talking to a king?

TEIRESIAS

I know. Who helped you save this town you hold?

CREON

You're a wise seer, but you love wickedness.

TEIRESIAS

1060 You'll bring me to speak the unspeakable, very soon.

CREON

Well, speak it out. But do not speak for profit.

TEIRESIAS

Do I seem to have spoken for profit, with regard to you?

CREON

Know this, that you can't buy and sell my policies.

TEIRESIAS

1065 Know well yourself, the sun won't roll its course
many more days, before you come to give
corpse for these corpses, child of your own loins.
For you've confused the upper and lower worlds.
You settled a living person without honor
1070 in a tomb; you keep up here that which belongs
below, a corpse unburied and unholy.
Not you, nor any god on high should have
any business with this. The violation's yours.
So the patient, foul punishers lie in wait
1075 to track you down: the Furies sent by Hades
and by all gods will even you with your victims.
Now say that I am bribed! The time is close
when men and women shall wail within your house,
1080 and all the cities that you fought in war^o
whose sons had burial from wild beasts, or dogs,
or birds that brought the stench of your great wrong
back to each hearth, they all will move against you.
1085 A bowman, as you said, I send my shafts,
since you provoked me, straight. You'll feel the wound.
Boy, take me home now. Let him spend his rage
on younger men, and learn to calm his tongue,

1090 and keep a better mind than now he does.

(Exit, to the side.)

CHORUS LEADER

Lord, he has gone. Terrible prophecies!
And since the time my hair turned gray from black,
his sayings to the city have been true.

CREON

1095 I also know this. And my mind is torn.
To yield is dreadful. But to stand against him,
and shatter my spirit in doom is dreadful too.

CHORUS LEADER

Now you must seek good counsel, and take advice.

CREON

What must I do? Speak, and I shall obey.

CHORUS LEADER

1100 Go free the maiden from that rocky house;
and bury the dead who lies in readiness.

CREON

This is your counsel? You would have me yield?

CHORUS LEADER

Quick as you can. The gods move very fast
when they bring ruin on misguided men.

CREON

1105 How hard, abandonment of my desire!
But I can fight necessity no more.

CHORUS LEADER

Do it yourself. Leave it to no one else.

CREON

I'll go at once. Come, followers, to your work.

You that are here round up the other fellows.

Take axes with you, hurry to that place

1110 that overlooks us there.

And I, since my decision's overturned,

the one who bound her will set her free myself.

I've come to fear it's best to hold the laws

of old tradition to the end of life.

(Exit, to the side.)

CHORUS [*singing*]

STROPHE A

1115 *God of the many names, Semele's proud delight,*

child of Olympian thunder, Italy's master,

1120 *lord of Eleusis, where all men come*

to Mother Demeter's plain:

Bacchus, who dwell in Thebes,

by Ismenus' running water,

where wild Bacchic women are at home,

1125 *on the soil of the dragon seed.*

ANTISTROPHE A

Seen in the glaring flame, high on the double crags,

with the nymphs of Parnassus at play on the hill,

1130 *seen by Castalia's fresh fountain:*

you come from the ivied heights

and the green grape-filled coast of Euboea.

In immortal words they cry

1135 *your name, lord, who watch the roads,*
the many streets of Thebes.

STROPHE B

This is your city, honored beyond the rest,
the town of your mother's miracle-death.
1140 *Now, as we wrestle with grim disease,*
come with healing step along Parnassus' slope
1145 *or over the resounding sea.*

ANTISTROPHE B

Leader in dance of the fire-pulsing stars,
overseer of the voices of night,
child of Zeus, be manifest,
1150 *with due companionship of maenads dancing*
and honoring their lord, Iacchus.

(Enter Messenger, from the side.)

MESSENGER

1155 Neighbors of Cadmus, and Amphion's house,
there is no kind of state in human life
which I would now dare either praise or blame.
Fortune sets straight, and Fortune overturns
the happy or unhappy, day by day.
1160 No prophecy can deal with men's affairs.
Creon was envied once, as I believe,
for having saved this city from its foes
and having got full power in this land.
He steered it well. And he had noble sons.
1165 Now everything is gone.
Yes, when a man has lost all happiness,
he's not alive. Call him a breathing corpse.
Be very rich at home. Live as a king.

But once your joy has gone, though these are left
1170 they are smoke's shadow to lost happiness.

CHORUS LEADER

What is the grief of princes that you bring?

MESSENGER

They're dead. The living are responsible.

CHORUS LEADER

Who died? Who did the murder? Tell us now.

MESSENGER

1175 Haemon is gone. His own flesh and blood did him in.

CHORUS LEADER

But whose arm struck? His father's or his own?

MESSENGER

He killed himself, angry at his father's killing.

CHORUS LEADER

Seer, all too true the prophecy you told!

MESSENGER

This is the state of things. Now make your plans.

(Enter Eurydice, from the palace.)

CHORUS LEADER

1180 Eurydice is with us now, I see.

Creon's poor wife. She may have come by chance.

She may have heard something about her son.

EURYDICE

I heard your talk as I was coming out
1185 to greet the goddess Pallas with my prayer.
And as I moved the bolts that held the door
I heard the voice of family disaster.
I fell back fainting in my women's arms.
1190 But say again, just what is the news you bring.
I, whom you speak to, have known grief before.

MESSENGER

Dear lady, I was there, and I shall tell,
leaving out nothing of the true account.
Why should I make it soft for you with tales
1195 to prove myself a liar? Truth is right.
I followed your husband to the plain's far edge,
where Polyneices' corpse was lying still
unpitied. The dogs had torn him all apart.
We prayed the goddess of all journeyings,
1200 and Pluto, that they turn their wrath to kindness;
we gave the final purifying bath,
then burned the poor remains on new-cut boughs,
and heaped a high mound of his native earth.
Then turned we to the maiden's rocky bed,
1205 approaching Hades' hollow marriage chamber.
But, still far off, one of us heard a voice
in keen lament by that unblest abode.
He ran and told the master. As Creon came
1210 he heard confusion crying. He groaned and spoke:
"Am I a prophet now, and do I tread
the saddest of all roads I ever trod?
My son's voice crying! Servants, run up close,
1215 stand by the tomb and look, push through the crevice
where we built the pile of rock, right to the entry.
Find out if that is Haemon's voice I hear
or if the gods are tricking me indeed."

We obeyed the order of our mournful master.
1220 In the far corner of the tomb we saw
her, hanging by the neck, caught in a noose
of her own linen veiling.
Haemon embraced her as she hung, and mourned
his bride's destruction, dead and gone below,
1225 his father's actions, the unfated marriage.
When Creon saw him, he groaned terribly,
and went toward him, and called him with lament:
"What have you done, what did you have in mind,
what happened so as thus to ruin you?
1230 Come out, my child, I do beseech you, come!"
The boy looked at him with his angry eyes,
spat in his face and spoke no further word.
He drew his sword, but as his father ran,
he missed his aim. Then the unhappy boy,
1235 in anger at himself, leant on the blade:
it entered, half its length, into his side.
While he was conscious he embraced the maiden,
holding her gently. Last, he gasped out blood,
red blood on her white cheek.
1240 Corpse on a corpse he lies. He found his marriage,
its celebration in the halls of Hades.
So he has made it very clear to men
that to reject good counsel is a crime.

(Exit Eurydice, back into the palace.)

CHORUS LEADER

What do you make of this? The queen has gone
1245 in silence, with no word of evil or of good.

MESSENGER

I wonder at her, too. But we can hope

that she has gone to mourn her son within
with her own women, not before the town.
1250 She knows discretion. She will do no wrong.

CHORUS LEADER

I am not sure. This muteness may portend
as great disaster as a loud lament.

MESSENGER

I will go in and see if some deep plan
1255 hides in her heart's wild pain. You may be right.
There can be heavy danger in mute grief.

*(Exit the Messenger into the palace. Creon enters from the side
with his followers. They are carrying Haemon's body on a bier.)*

CHORUS [*chanting*]

*But look, the king draws near.
His own hand brings
the witness of his crime,
1260 the doom he brought on himself.*

CREON [*singing in what follows, while the Chorus and Messenger speak*]

STROPHE A

*O crimes of my wicked heart,
harshness bringing death.
You see the killer, you see the kin he killed.
1265 My planning was all unblest.
Son, you have died too soon.
Oh, you have gone away
through my fault, not your own.*

CHORUS LEADER

1270 You have learned justice, though it comes too late.

CREON

*Yes, I have learned in sorrow. It was a god who struck,
who has weighted my head with disaster; he drove me to wild strange ways,
1275 his heavy heel on my joy.
Oh sorrows, sorrows of men.*

(Reenter the Messenger, from the palace.)

MESSENGER

*Master, you hold one sorrow in your hands
1280 but you have more, stored up inside the house.*

CREON

What further suffering can come on me?

MESSENGER

*Your wife has died. The dead man's mother indeed,
poor soul, with wounds freshly inflicted.*

CREON

ANTISTROPHE A

*Hades, harbor of all,
1285 you have destroyed me now.
Terrible news to hear, horror the tale you tell.
I was dead, and you kill me again.
1290 Boy, did I hear you right?
Did you say the queen was dead,
slaughter on slaughter heaped?*

*(The central doors of the palace open, and
the corpse of Eurydice is revealed.)*

CHORUS LEADER

Now you can see. Concealment is all over.

CREON

1295 *My second sorrow is here. Surely no fate remains*
which can strike me again. Just now, I held my son in my arms.
And now I see her dead.
1300 *Woe for the mother and son.*

MESSENGER

There, by the altar, dying on the sword,
her eyes fell shut. She wept her older son,
Megareus, who died before, and this one. Finally
1305 she cursed you as the killer of her children.

CREON

STROPHE B

I am mad with fear. Will no one strike
and kill me with cutting sword?
1310 *Sorrowful, soaked in sorrow to the bone!*

MESSENGER

Yes, for she held you guilty in the death
of him before you, and the elder dead.

CREON

How did she die?

MESSENGER

1315 Struck home at her own heart
when she had heard of Haemon's suffering.

CREON

This is my guilt, all mine. I killed you, I say it clear.

1320 *Servants, take me away, out of the sight of men.*

1325 *I who am nothing more than nothing now.*

CHORUS LEADER

Your plan is good—if any good is left.

Best to cut short our sorrow.

CREON

ANTISTROPHE B

Let me go, let me go. May death come quick,

1330 *bringing my final day!*

O let me never see tomorrow's dawn.

CHORUS LEADER

That is the future's. We must look to now.

1335 What will be is in other hands than ours.

CREON

All my desire was in that prayer of mine.

CHORUS LEADER

Pray not again. No mortal can escape
the doom prepared for him.

CREON [*singing*]

1340 *Take me away at once, the frantic man who killed
my son, against my meaning, and you too, my wife.
I cannot look at either, I cannot rest.*

1345 *My life is warped past cure. Fate unbearable
has leapt down on my head.*

(Creon and his attendants enter the palace.)

CHORUS [*chanting*]

Our happiness depends

on wisdom all the way.

The gods must have their due.

1350 *Great words by men of pride*
bring greater blows upon them.
So wisdom comes to the old.